been a vote-winner in Indian politics. Yet, for Nehru, his pivotal role in global affairs, his creation of the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) and his outsized role as spokesperson for the postcolonial developing world were inseparable from his influence at home and his irreplaceability as a domestic leader. Of course, globalism was a key part of Indira Gandhi's politics too. She used the pageantry of NAM summits and domestic events like the 1982 Asian Games to play statesman. Rajiv Gandhi's youthful image symbolised a new India, and Manmohan Singh's erudition led to US President Barack Obama praising him as a 'man with uncommon wisdom', who even appeared 'holy' to the 'Western eye'.[38] But no one since Nehru has made the perception of foreign clout as central to their local imagery as Modi has.

In his first three speeches to the nation during the first national lockdown imposed due to the pandemic in 2020, it was telling how much of Modi's discourse focused on the term 'vaishvik mahamaari corona', or global epidemic. He stressed on what other, more developed countries, with greater resources than India, were doing and how India's response compared with theirs. In his third speech, for example, when he announced a ₹20 lakh crore package, he made it a point to emphasise that the US had devoted about 10 per cent of its GDP in its package and that India was doing the same.[39] The global is both local and fundamental to his political positioning.

Liberals sniggered at images of Modi hugging Obama during the US President's India visit and over his quip that his relationship with Obama was 'tu-tarake ka rishta' (colloquial Hindi idiom for an informal friendship where friends address each other with the informal 'tu' as opposed to the respectful 'aap'). They debated whether the semantics made any sense, but they missed the significance of the domestic political signalling. A status of equality and clout with global leaders, including with Obama's successor Donald Trump, was fundamental to Modi's domestic positioning as well. It is no coincidence that the semi-official book on the *Mann ki Baat* series, produced with the 'cooperation of the Narendra Modi app team' and written largely for an Indian audience, starts with an endorsement by the then Japanese prime minister Shinzo Abe. Or